

8 hours If your baby is awake, they may be hungry. At this stage, you're producing nutrient-rich colostrum, a fluid containing antibodies. Position them at the breast: they should open their mouth wide and take the entire areola, known as "**latching on**." Breastfeeding stimulates the release of the hormone oxytocin, which contracts the uterus. This can cause afterpains, more in second and subsequent births, which can feel like contractions. A consolation is that with each contraction, your uterus—and hence your abdomen—shrinks down.

9 hours If you're up to it, you may be ready for visitors to admire your baby. Don't let them tire you out, though.

10 hours Your baby's newborn checkups will take place when they're between 4 and 48 hours old. A staff pediatrician will examine them from head to toe; listen to their heart, check their hips (and testes in a boy); and ask about the contents of their diapers.

11 hours In many hospitals, you can spend your first night as a new family together, since rooming-in with the baby is a common practice and new partners often sleep over. This lets the nurses see how mother and baby interact. If you need to get a few hours of uninterrupted sleep, a nurse can take the baby to the nursery.

12 hours After a whirlwind of agony, ecstasy, and sheer hard labor, you need to rest when you can. If your baby is sleeping, fend off visitors, draw the curtains around your bed, or take the phone off the hook, and sleep.



Nothing compares with the moment when you meet your baby face to face.